

MEMORY & THINKING CHANGES

Recognizing Memory Changes

Some changes come with normal aging. Others are worth discussing with a doctor.

Area	Changes to Discuss with a Doctor	Normal Aging
Familiar Tasks	Having a hard time cooking meals, paying bills, or driving to places you know well	Needing someone to help set up the TV remote or microwave
Judgement	Giving away money to strangers, falling for scams, or not keeping up with bathing	Making a bad choice once in a while
Communication	Losing track during a conversation, stopping mid-sentence, or calling things by the wrong name	Having a word “on the tip of your tongue” but finding it later
Memory	Asking the same question over and over, or forgetting something you just learned	Forgetting someone’s name but remembering it later
Misplacing Items	Putting things in odd places (like keys in the fridge) and not being able to find them	Losing your glasses but being able to retrace your steps
Mood & Behavior	Getting upset, scared, or suspicious much more easily than before	Feeling cranky when your routine changes
Planning	Trouble following a recipe, keeping track of bills, or working with numbers	Making a mistake in your checkbook once in a while
Social Withdrawal	Dropping out of hobbies, church, or social activities you used to enjoy	Not feeling like going out every now and then
Time/Place Orientation	Getting confused about what day, month, or season it is, or getting lost in a familiar place	Forgetting what day of the week it is for a moment
Visual Perception	Trouble with balance, reading, or judging how far away things are (not caused by eye problems)	Having blurry vision because of cataracts or needing new glasses

Understanding Memory Changes

As we get older, some changes in memory and thinking are normal. But some changes may be early signs of a medical condition that a doctor should know about.

Seeing a doctor early can help in many ways:

- **Rule out fixable causes:** Some memory problems are caused by medications, vitamin levels, thyroid problems, or depression. These can often be treated or reversed.
- **Plan ahead:** An early diagnosis gives you and your family time to make important decisions about care, finances, and daily life while you are still able to.
- **Get support:** Programs like support groups, caregiver classes, and respite care can make a real difference for families – and the sooner you connect, the more they can help.
- **Explore treatment options:** There are medications that may help slow memory loss, and healthy habits like exercise, staying social, and eating well can support brain health.

This chart is for general awareness only. It is not a diagnosis or a screening result.

MEMORY & THINKING CHANGES

Changes You've Noticed

Check anything that sounds familiar, then bring this to your appointment to share clear examples.

Name: _____ **Date:** _____

What changes have you or your family noticed? Check all that apply:

- ☐ Asking the same question or telling the same story over and over
- ☐ Trouble with everyday tasks that used to be easy (cooking, paying bills, taking medicines)
- ☐ Getting lost or confused in familiar places
- ☐ Mood or personality changes (new worry, fear, suspicion, or pulling away from people)
- ☐ Missing appointments or forgetting to take medicines
- ☐ Trouble with money — unusual spending, missed payments, or falling victim to scams
- ☐ Losing interest in hobbies or activities they used to enjoy
- ☐ Trouble learning how to use new things (remote, phone, microwave)
- ☐ Forgetting what month, season, or year it is
- ☐ Having a hard time following conversations or finding the right words

Are these changes getting:

- ☐ Better ☐ Worse ☐ About the same

When did you first notice these changes?

- ☐ Less than 6 months ☐ 6 months – 1 year ☐ 1 – 2 years
☐ More than 2 years ☐ Unknown

This checklist is a tool to help you share clear examples with a doctor. It is not a diagnosis or a screening result.

MEMORY & THINKING CHANGES

Medication List

List everything you take — prescriptions, over-the-counter medicines, vitamins, and supplements — and bring it to your appointment.

Name: _____ **Date:** _____

Medication Name	Dose	How Often	Currently Taking?
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No

Tip: Update this list whenever a medication changes and bring a copy to every appointment.

Questions to Discuss with Your Doctor

Bring this with you to your appointment. Check the questions that feel most important to you.

Understanding the Cause

- ☐ Could any of my medicines be causing memory problems?
- ☐ Could something else be causing these changes, like depression, sleep problems, hearing loss, thyroid problems, or a vitamin shortage?

Testing and Evaluation

- ☐ Should I have a memory test done in the office?
- ☐ Do I need any blood tests or a brain scan?

Understanding the Results

- ☐ Are the changes I have noticed serious enough to affect my daily life, or could this be mild cognitive impairment?
- ☐ Should I see a specialist?

Next Steps and Planning

- ☐ Is there anything I can do now, like exercise, diet, or other changes, to protect my brain health?
- ☐ What should I watch for, and when should I come back?
- ☐ If this turns out to be dementia, what should we start planning for now?

This sheet is meant to help you prepare for your visit. It is not a diagnosis or a screening result.